

RELATED CONDITIONS

Illness anxiety disorder

Also known as health anxiety or hypochondria, people with illness anxiety disorder are preoccupied with having or contracting disease. They may have no physical symptoms but view normal experiences as serious illness indicators, constantly monitoring themselves and seeking reassurance due to anxiety.

Conversion disorder

In conversion disorder, neurological symptoms such as paralysis, numb limbs, visual problems, and motor issues arise as a result of psychological stress. The condition is most common in people with early or lifelong experience of trauma. Therapy and lifestyle change usually result in recovery.

Somatic symptom disorder

Somatic symptom disorder (SSD) is characterized by an extreme focus on physical symptoms that may or may not be related to an actual diagnosed medical condition. People with SSD, however, truly believe they are ill, and their distress is experienced as bodily, or “somatic” symptoms.

SSD is closely linked to anxiety and depression. Physical manifestations often include pain, weakness, and fatigue; shortness of breath is another common complaint.

Those affected worry excessively about their health and focus on one or several symptoms, even when a medical cause cannot be found for

the physical problems they describe. If a diagnosis is found, SSD sufferers are so focused on their conditions that they are often unable to function normally.

Treatment includes antidepressants as well as therapies such as cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT).

Munchausen syndrome

Munchausen syndrome is caused by severe emotional distress. It is classed as a factitious disorder—a mental-health condition in which a person acts mentally or physically ill, purposefully fabricating symptoms.

Munchausen syndrome is a rare psychological illness and tends to occur in people who have had traumatic early life events, such as emotional abuse or illness, who have a personality disorder, or who harbor resentment toward authority figures. It is believed to be an extreme form of attention-seeking behavior. Those affected may tell stories of dramatic occurrences, lie about symptoms, make symptoms worse by deliberately aggravating wounds or ingesting toxins, and even alter test results and falsify records.

A new form of the disorder has been termed Munchausen by internet, in which a person pretends to have a specific illness and joins an online support group for real sufferers of the disease.

COMMON SYMPTOMS OF FACTITIOUS DISORDERS

Here are some of the symptoms commonly seen in patients with Munchausen syndrome and other factitious disorders.

A long medical history, often including frequent hospitalization at different locations and visits to several doctors.

Extensive textbook knowledge of the disease reported, as well as of medical practice in general.

A willingness to submit to medical tests, investigations, and even surgery.

An unwillingness to allow medical staff to contact friends and family, or having few visitors when hospitalized.

Many surgical scars or evidence of numerous procedures.

Conditions that get worse for no apparent reason, or which don't respond as expected to standard therapies.

MUNCHAUSEN SYNDROME BY PROXY

Munchausen by proxy is a type of factitious disorder in which carers fabricate or physically induce symptoms of illness or injury in those under their control. Also considered a type of physical and mental abuse, it is usually inflicted on young children by a parent, but sometimes on other vulnerable people under the control of a caregiver, such as an elderly parent being looked after by a son or daughter.

